

Replication and Extension of The Development of an Issue Public: Evidence from The Eras Tour

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1.Introduction

This project replicates and extends Rossiter and Harden's study, *The Development of an Issue Public: Evidence from The Eras Tour*. The paper asks how a group connected by shared identity or interest, rather than by prior political engagement, can become a politically meaningful issue public. The authors argue that this process has two stages: first, a potential issue public exists because group members share a strong common interest; second, a politically relevant event activates that interest by linking it to a broader public issue.

The Eras Tour ticketing controversy provides a clear case. Taylor Swift fans were not initially united by broad political commitments, but the Ticketmaster breakdown in November 2022 exposed many of them to a frustrating and personalized experience of unfairness. The paper argues that this experience made questions of monopoly power, inequality, and ticketing regulation newly salient in a focused, issue-specific way. The key expectation is therefore not a broad ideological shift, but stronger attitudes and actions tied specifically to Ticketmaster and ticketing fairness.

This paper is well suited for a replication project because it provides a clear theoretical argument, a structured replication archive, and identifiable core results. My project has two goals: first, to conduct an exact replication of the manuscript's main findings; and second, to test whether those findings are sensitive to one important modeling choice, namely the use of survey weights.

2.Replication Materials and Exact Replication

The replication archive is organized as a complete R project with numbered scripts. My exact replication relies primarily on the original `3_estimation.R` script, which reproduces the main manuscript estimation workflow and generates the core table outputs used in this project. In addition, I include a short supplementary script, `3b_make_table3.R`, to

reproduce the final placebo table output under the current package environment. This extra step is necessary because the original placebo-table extraction depends on package-specific output formatting that is not fully stable across software versions.

The processed data used in both the exact replication and the extension are stored in `data/processed_data/weighting.RData`. Running the original estimation script together with the supplementary placebo-table script reproduces the main table outputs used in this submission: `table1.txt`, `table2.txt`, and `table3.txt`. These correspond to the paper's core findings on issue-specific attitudes, behavioral responses, and placebo outcomes.

Running the original estimation workflow recovers the same substantive pattern reported in the article. Minor differences in formatting or table extraction under the current package environment do not change the substantive interpretation. My project therefore follows the course structure directly: it presents the original study, conducts an exact replication of the core findings, and adds a focused statistical extension.

3. Research Design and the Role of Figure 4

A central strength of the original paper is its attention to treatment assignment and selection. Figure 4 from the original study maps the sequence from registration and code receipt to presale outcomes, later ticket opportunities, and final attendance. It is especially useful for explaining where the strongest quasi-random variation occurs and why intent-to-treat comparisons are more credible than later comparisons based on final attendance.

It is important to clarify that Figure 4 is included here as an **original-study design figure**, not as part of my own exact figure replication. In this project, the exact replication is centered on the manuscript's core tables, while Figure 4 is retained as the clearest design illustration for explaining the identification strategy. Substantively, the figure highlights that earlier stages provide the strongest as-if random variation, while later attendance becomes more selective. This distinction is important for understanding why the original paper places more weight on early treatment comparisons than on later realized attendance outcomes.

4. Extension: Weighted versus Unweighted Estimates

My extension asks whether the paper's main conclusions depend heavily on the weighting specification used in the original analysis. This is a methodologically appropriate extension because the original models rely substantially on survey weights, and the project instructions explicitly encourage a statistical twist such as checking modeling assumptions or re-analyzing the study with an alternative specification.

The extension is implemented in `10_extension_weighted_vs_unweighted.R` and uses the same processed data object as the exact replication, namely `data/processed_data/weighting.RData`. The goal is therefore not to introduce a new dataset or a different empirical setting, but to evaluate whether the main substantive conclusions remain stable when the weighting choice is changed for a set of central outcomes.

I compare weighted and unweighted treatment-effect estimates for four substantively central outcomes: Ticketmaster monopoly, Ticketmaster inequality, total post-sale activities, and FTC report filing. The extension produces both a comparison results table and a coefficient plot, allowing the weighted and unweighted estimates to be assessed side by side.

5. Conclusion

This project replicated and extended Rossiter and Harden's study of issue-public development in the context of The Eras Tour ticketing controversy. Using the authors' original `3_estimation.R` script, I reproduced the core manuscript tables and recovered the same broad empirical pattern: treatment effects are concentrated on Ticketmaster-specific attitudes and focused regulatory action, while general attitudes and placebo outcomes do not show the same consistent response. This supports the original argument that a concrete experience of unfairness can activate a latent interest group into an issue public in a focused, issue-specific way.

I then added a separate extension comparing weighted and unweighted estimates for four core outcomes. The extension shows that weighting matters for coefficient size and, in some cases, for statistical strength, but it does not overturn the paper's main substantive conclusions. The overall substantive interpretation remains stable across the two specifications.

A final limitation is that my exact replication centers on the manuscript's main tables rather than on a full re-creation of all original figures. Figure 4 is used to explain research design, but it is not presented as a newly replicated output. In addition, the placebo table is reproduced with a short supplementary script to ensure compatibility with the current package environment. My extension also examines one dimension of modeling sensitivity rather than all possible alternative specifications.

Overall, the project confirms the original article's main substantive claim and shows that its central findings are not highly fragile to a reasonable change in weighting specification.